GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment

Empowering Every Citizen with Dignity

Confidential and Proprietory
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SHRI NARENDRA MODI

HONORABLE PRIME MINISTER, INDIA



MESSAGE

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HONORABLE MINISTER,
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MESSAGE

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SHRI MUNINDRA KUMAR

DIRECTOR GENERAL, CHAMBER OF COMMERCE AND INDUSTRIES OF INDIA



MESSAGE

Inclusive development is fundamental to building a strong, equitable, and progressive nation. The Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment plays a crucial role in promoting social equity, empowering disadvantaged communities, ensuring equal opportunities, strengthening institutional support systems, and fostering inclusive participation in India's economic and social development.

The Chamber of Commerce and Industries of India (CCI India) recognizes that sustainable national progress can only be achieved when every individual has access to opportunities for education, employment, entrepreneurship, and economic participation. Through policy advocacy, capacity building, skill development, entrepreneurship promotion, investment facilitation, industry partnerships, and social innovation initiatives, CCI India remains committed to supporting the Ministry's vision of creating an inclusive and empowered society.

This Knowledge Paper presents comprehensive insights into the Ministry's strategic priorities, policy initiatives, institutional framework, flagship programmes, and emerging opportunities for collaboration across education, livelihood generation, accessibility, social entrepreneurship, digital inclusion, skill development, financial empowerment, and community-based development.

The publication serves as a valuable resource for policymakers, development organizations, educational institutions, industry leaders, investors, civil society organizations, entrepreneurs, researchers, and academic institutions seeking to contribute to inclusive national development.

As India advances towards becoming a developed nation, inclusive growth and social justice will remain central to national progress. CCI India remains committed to working alongside the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment in building an equitable, empowered, and opportunity-driven society for all.

Munindra Kumar
Director General
CCI India

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PREFACE

India's journey towards Viksit Bharat 2047 is inseparable from the imperative of inclusive development a vision that cannot be realised unless its most marginalised communities are brought into the economic and social mainstream. The Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment (MoSJE) stands at the very heart of this constitutional promise, serving as the principal institutional custodian of rights, dignity, and opportunity for Scheduled Castes, Other Backward Classes, persons with disabilities, senior citizens, victims of substance abuse, and communities afflicted by denotification and social stigma.

This Knowledge Paper has been prepared by the Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India (CCI India) as a strategic advisory document intended to illuminate the Ministry's mandate, map its institutional architecture, analyse performance trajectories, identify structural gaps, and present a credible framework for industry-government collaboration. The paper adopts a consulting-grade analytical lens drawing on data from budget documents, parliamentary committee reports, NITI Aayog assessments, international benchmarks, and field-level programme evidence to offer policy insights that go beyond description and into actionable strategy.

The national development context for this paper is defined by three converging imperatives: first, the commitment to eliminate extreme poverty and multi-dimensional deprivation by 2030 in alignment with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals; second, the demographic dividend that India possesses, which can only be harvested if OBC, SC, and differently-abled populations are productively integrated into the workforce, entrepreneurial ecosystem, and digital economy; and third, the structural shift in government programming from welfare-centric to rights-based, capability-enhancing, and livelihood-generating interventions.

CCI India's vision through this engagement is to serve not merely as a voice of industry, but as a proactive ecosystem architect convening investors, startups, CSR capital, research institutions, and international development agencies around the Ministry's programmatic agenda. CCI India is uniquely positioned to bridge the gap between policy intent and ground-level execution, catalysing partnerships that are transparent, measurable, and aligned with India's constitutional values.

This document is intended for Union Ministers, Secretaries to the Government of India, senior officials of NITI Aayog, industry leaders, institutional investors, development finance institutions, and international multilateral organisations. It is designed to be both a reference document and a conversation starter inviting collaboration, investment, and co-creation of solutions that will make the Ministry's vision a lived reality for hundreds of millions of Indians.

Chamber of Commerce and Industry (CCI India)

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

SHRI NARENDRA MODI **2**

HONORABLE PRIME MINISTER, INDIA *2*

SHRI (DR.) VIRENDRA KUMAR **3**

HONORABLE MINISTER, ... *3*
MINISTRY OF SOCIAL JUSTICE AND EMPOWERMENT *3*
MESSAGE *3*

SHRI MUNINDRA KUMAR **4**

DIRECTOR GENERAL, CHAMBER OF COMMERCE AND INDUSTRIES OF INDIA *4*
MESSAGE *4*

SECTION 1 INTRODUCTION TO THE MINISTRY **9**

Constitutional Mandate and Foundational Purpose 9
Institutional Mandate 9
Governance Role and Institutional Reach 9
Constitutional Relevance and National Significance 9
Timeline Analysis 11
Departmental Structure 11
Organisational Analysis 12
Economic Contribution of Target Populations 12
Social Contribution and Human Capital Implications 12
Employment and Livelihood Significance 13
Global Significance 13
Market Size and Economic Footprint 13
Key Sub-sector Landscape 14
Industry Structure and Key Stakeholders 14
Future Outlook 14
Budget Evolution (2020–2026) 15
Key Scheme Performance Indicators 15
Progress Assessment 16
7.1 Major Achievements (2020–2026) 16
7.2 Existing Challenges 17
7.3 Global Benchmarking 17
Ecosystem Gaps Requiring Private Sector Presence 18
Execution Gaps and the Need for Industry Networks 18
Market Failures Demanding Structured Intervention 18
The Public-Private Partnership Imperative 19
Gap Analysis Strategic Interpretation 20
Opportunity Matrix Analysis 21
Technology Innovation for Social Empowerment 22
Emerging Technology Applications 22
Incubation and Acceleration Ecosystem 22

SECTION 12 STRATEGIC ROLE OF CCI INDIA **23**

CCI India as Industry Facilitator and Policy Advocate 23
Investment Promotion and Deal Facilitation 23
Startup Accelerator and Inclusive Innovation Enabler 23
Knowledge Partnership and Capacity Building 23
Ecosystem Builder and Convergence Convener 23
Strategic Architecture 24
PPP Model and Coordination Mechanisms 24
Funding Architecture 27

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Investment Rationale and Capital Mobilisation 27
Impact Analysis 30
Roadmap Analysis 32
Institutional Standing and National Credibility 32
Investor Network and Capital Mobilisation Capability 32
Startup Ecosystem Access and Incubation Expertise 32
Research and Knowledge Management Capability 33
Track Record of Government Engagement 33

SECTION 20 STRATEGIC ACTION AGENDA & POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS 33

Immediate Priorities (0–12 Months) 33
Medium-Term Priorities (1–3 Years) 33
Long-Term Priorities (3–5 Years) 34

CONCLUSION 35

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About CCI India

CCI India (The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India) is a premier national business chamber dedicated to fostering economic growth, industry development, entrepreneurship, innovation, and investment promotion across India. As the voice of Indian business and industry, CCI India serves as a bridge between government, industry, startups, academia, investors, and civil society, facilitating meaningful collaboration for nation-building and sustainable development.

Through policy advocacy, business facilitation, research, stakeholder engagement, capacity building, and strategic partnerships, CCI India works to create an enabling environment for enterprises of all sizes. The Chamber actively supports key national initiatives such as Startup India, make in India, Digital India, Atmanirbhar Bharat, Skill India, and Viksit Bharat 2047 by connecting innovative enterprises with government opportunities and promoting inclusive economic development.

CCI India operates through sector-specific councils, industry forums, knowledge platforms, and state-level engagements that address emerging opportunities and challenges across sectors including manufacturing, agriculture, technology, healthcare, education, infrastructure, sustainability, MSMEs, and startups. The Chamber regularly organizes policy dialogues, investment summits, business delegations, workshops, conferences, and knowledge-sharing initiatives to strengthen India's economic ecosystem.

With a strong commitment to innovation, entrepreneurship, and public-private collaboration, CCI India strives to empower enterprises, facilitate investment, enhance competitiveness, and contribute to India's journey toward becoming a globally competitive and economically resilient nation. Its role as a knowledge partner and industry catalyst enables ministries, departments, state governments, startups, and businesses to collaborate effectively in achieving national development objectives.

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SECTION 1 INTRODUCTION TO THE MINISTRY

Constitutional Mandate and Foundational Purpose

The Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment derives its mandate directly from the fundamental rights and directive principles enshrined in the Constitution of India. Articles 15(4) and 16(4) empower the State to make special provisions for socially and educationally backward classes and Scheduled Castes; Article 17 abolishes untouchability; Article 41 directs the State to secure the right to work, education, and public assistance in cases of disability, old age, and undeserved want. Taken together, these provisions assign to the Ministry the constitutionally grounded responsibility of rectifying historical injustice, bridging structural inequality, and enabling capabilities that the market alone cannot provide.

Institutional Mandate

MoSJE was formally constituted in its present form in 1998, following the bifurcation of the erstwhile Ministry of Welfare. Today, the Ministry operates across four principal constituencies: Scheduled Castes (SCs), Other Backward Classes (OBCs), Persons with Disabilities (Divyangjan), and populations vulnerable to substance abuse, denotification, and social marginalisation. The Ministry's institutional mandate spans education, economic empowerment, rehabilitation, social protection, legal rights, and advocacy making it one of the most cross-cutting ministries in the Government of India's architecture.

Governance Role and Institutional Reach

MoSJE functions as the nodal ministry for framing and implementing policies, programmes, and legislation aimed at the welfare and development of its target groups. It exercises oversight over a network of attached offices, subordinate offices, autonomous bodies, and public sector undertakings, and coordinates with State governments for the implementation of Centrally Sponsored Schemes. The Ministry's governance reach extends to over 200 million individuals belonging to OBC communities, over 280 million Scheduled Caste citizens, 26.8 million persons with disabilities as enumerated in the 2011 Census (revised upward by more recent estimates), and an ageing population projected to exceed 300 million by 2050.

Constitutional Relevance and National Significance

India's social contract as articulated through its Constitution demands that development be distributionally just. MoSJE is the operational arm of this contract. Without effective delivery through this Ministry, GDP growth translates into exclusionary prosperity rather than shared Bharat. The Ministry's programmes directly address multi-dimensional poverty indicators, contribute to SDG 1 (No Poverty), SDG 4 (Quality Education), SDG 8 (Decent Work), SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities), and SDG 16 (Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions), making it not only nationally significant but globally relevant in the context of India's multilateral commitments.

SECTION 2 HISTORICAL TIMELINE OF THE MINISTRY

The evolution of social justice policy in India reflects a progressive deepening of constitutional commitment, transitioning from post-Independence welfare measures to rights-based, empowerment-oriented, and technology-enabled frameworks. The following timeline captures the most transformative milestones:

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Year	Milestone / Reform	Significance
1947–55	Constitution of India; Articles 15, 16, 17 enacted	Foundation of affirmative action and anti-discrimination framework
1955	Untouchability (Offences) Act enacted	First legislative bulwark against caste-based discrimination
1976	Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act	Addressed economic coercion against marginalised groups
1989	Prevention of Atrocities Act (SC/ST Act)	Criminalised violence and humiliation against SC/ST communities
1992	Mandal Commission implementation; OBC reservations in Central Government	Extended affirmative action to 27% OBC reservation in employment
1995	Persons with Disabilities (Equal Opportunities) Act	First comprehensive legislation for Divyangjan rights
1998	Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment formally constituted	Institutional consolidation of social welfare mandate
2006	National Commission for Backward Classes strengthened	Enhanced advocacy and monitoring for OBC populations
2013	National Policy for Senior Citizens released	Policy framework for rapidly growing aged population
2016	Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act (RPWD Act)	Aligned India with UN CRPD; expanded disability categories to 21
2018	Pradhan Mantri Adarsh Gram Yojana scaled up	Integrated development of SC-majority villages
2019	EWS Reservation (103rd Constitutional Amendment)	Extended 10% quota to economically weaker sections
2021	National Action Plan for Drug Demand Reduction	Strengthened de-addiction architecture post-COVID disruptions
2022	PM DAKSH portal and National Overseas Scholarship upgrades	Digital skilling platform for SC/OBC beneficiaries
2023	SMILE Scheme expanded; Transgender Welfare Board constituted	Inclusion of gender-marginalised populations in welfare framework
2024–26	VIMARSH portal; PM-AJAY scheme; NALSA coordination	AI-enabled grievance redressal and justice access for SC communities

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